12-Week Plan v2: Senior, Technical and AI Product Manager

7 Oct to 27 Dec 2026 (buffer 28 to 31 Dec). Weeks run Monday to Sunday. Track 1 is the focus; Principal PM is parked.

Goal by week 12

- A PM-framed CV and LinkedIn that get replies
- 6 sharp product stories
- A working, evaluated AI project (call-insights-copilot) with a PRD and architecture document in a public repo
- Enough technical fluency to hold your own with engineers
- A live pipeline of interviews for Senior, Technical or AI PM roles in CX and enterprise AI
- Track 2 (Principal or Staff TPM, forward-deployed and AI solutions roles) at about 30% of application effort

How the plan works

Build
Hands-on coding in small steps, run yourself. Synthetic or public data only.

Make
A product document: teardown, metric tree, PRD, pricing sheet.

Say
Answer out loud: mock interviews and feedback.

Reach
Outreach and applications.

Concept of the Week
About 1 hour, weeks 2 to 10. Learn one non-AI system design idea, link it to your own experience, write 5 lines in your own words.

Hours
About 20 technical hours a week (25 in weeks 6 to 8), 7 search, 12 product practice, 2 admin: 41 to 46 in total, six days, one full day off.

Sample day

- Morning: outreach and applications (2.5 h)
- Midday: technical learning (2 h)
- Afternoon: product and interview practice (1.5 to 2 h)

- Evening free; stop at a fixed time
- Sunday review (30 min): replies, screens, shaky topic, weakest interview area, top 3 actions next week. Also score the self-test green, amber or red.

Public repo: **call-insights-copilot**. Each weekly build becomes a module, and nothing from Uniphore or its customers is used.

AI and supporting tech at the center

AI core
LLM calls and prompting, structured output, RAG, evals, agents and tools, MCP, guardrails, cost and token tracking, optional LangChain or LangGraph

Supporting tech
REST APIs and webhooks, SQL, Docker, cloud deploy, queues, security and PII, logging and monitoring, optional Kubernetes

Share of time
AI and supporting tech take about half of the weekly hours. Product, interview and outreach work wrap around it.

How to remember what you build

- Type every line yourself (no pasting) and explain each line aloud
- Break it on purpose once per build, then fix it
- Monday recall (15 min): rewrite last week's key snippet from memory
- One-page cheat sheet per week in the repo: snippet, command, one gotcha
- Daily 10-minute interview quiz (see below)
- Sunday teach-back: 2 minutes, out loud, no notes

These fit inside the existing technical hours and start in week 3.

Interview quizzes

Daily, Mon to Sat (10 min)
3 questions: one on AI, one on supporting tech, one on product or behavioral.

Sunday mock screen (15 min)
10 timed questions, scored green, amber or red. Feeds the 25-item self-test.

Checkpoint rounds (weeks 3, 5, 7, 10, 12; 30 min)
20 interview-style questions: multiple choice, spot the flaw, scenario, spoken answer.

The question bank is the 25 self-test items, your own stories and the Track 2 topics. Red items come back the next day, amber in 3 days, green in 7. Quizzes replace passive reading time, so weekly hours stay the same. They start in week 3.

Track 2 lane (about 30% of effort)

Principal or Staff TPM, forward-deployed and AI solutions roles. From week 3 each week has one small lab or story (about 1.5 h) taken from the Track 2 share of your time. Each one reuses the capstone.

Phases and checkpoints

Weeks 1 to 3 (7 to 25 Oct)
Screen-ready: intro pitch, three behavioral stories, product sense, metrics, AI basics, first public repo. Milestone: 25 Oct.

Weeks 4 to 5 (26 Oct to 8 Nov)
Core AI product skills: RAG, evals, first design drills. Checkpoint: 8 Nov reply-rate review.

Weeks 6 to 8 (9 to 29 Nov)
The agent arc: loop, MCP and orchestration, guardrails, observability, red-team tests, PRD. Checkpoint: 22 Nov. Fewer than 2 screens means widen titles and shift weight to Track 2.

Weeks 9 to 10 (30 Nov to 13 Dec)
Data and deployment: SQL, A/B testing, API in Docker, full mock loops. Fallback decision: 13 Dec.

Weeks 11 to 12 (14 to 27 Dec)
Polish and close: optional Kubernetes, portfolio polish, negotiation, January pipeline.

Week by week

▼ **Week 1: Foundations and first eval** (7 to 12 Oct, about 14 h) complete

BUILD	Day 5 scripts; regex and model refund checkers scored with precision and recall
MAKE	90-second intro and a 'why PM now' answer
SAY	Record intro once; coach feedback

REACH	10 messages (5 to 6 sent)
PORTFOLIO	Private repo with Day 1 to 5 scripts

▼ Week 2: Behavioral, product sense, APIs and retrieval basics (13 to 18 Oct, about 20 h) current

BUILD	Structured JSON output with error handling and retries; a real REST API call from Python; keyword-search mini retrieval over 5 synthetic FAQ documents, with sources cited
MAKE	Product teardown of one real product from the target list; finish the AXM story (own part: informed and consulted, not the decision-maker)
SAY	Behavioral mock 1 (intro and AXM)
REACH	8 to 10 messages, 3 to 4 applications
PORTFOLIO	README v0: problem statement and first architecture sketch
CONCEPT	APIs in depth: REST vs. webhook, status codes, API keys vs. OAuth, rate limits, idempotency

▼ Week 3: Execution, metrics and the first agent (19 to 25 Oct, about 20 h)

BUILD	Tool-use agent v0 with one tool (policy lookup); eval script scoring checker and agent on 20 cases; make the repo public
MAKE	Metric tree (with a latency guardrail metric); RICE prioritization; U-Analyze and Malayalam stories
SAY	Product sense and AI fluency mocks; design drill: sequence diagram of real-time agent assist (Siebel, Genesys)
REACH	8 to 10 messages, 3 to 4 applications; 3 teardowns for outreach
PORTFOLIO	Public repo, README, eval results table. Milestone 25 Oct: screen-ready
CONCEPT	Latency and SLAs: p50, p95, p99, throughput, SLA vs. SLO
TRACK 2	TPM story pack: the U-Assist phased release as a program story (risks, dependencies, decisions)

▼ Week 4: RAG (26 Oct to 1 Nov, about 22 h)

BUILD	Real retrieval with embeddings, chunking experiments, vector search with citations; compare with the week 2 keyword version on the same questions
MAKE	PRD v0; draft pricing sheet

SAY	Design drill: a RAG assistant for a contact center
REACH	Referral asks for specific open roles
PORTFOLIO	Architecture diagram v1; decision record 1
CONCEPT	Databases and caching: SQL vs. NoSQL, indexes, vector databases, cache hit and miss
TRACK 2	FDE story: Siebel with no APIs and the RPA workaround

▼ Week 5: Evals (Diwali week) (2 to 8 Nov, about 22 h)

BUILD	Eval harness: 40-case golden set (negation, conditionals, injection, paraphrase) covering refund promises and the required disclaimer, precision and recall, LLM judge with human spot check, regression runs, cost per call
MAKE	Pricing sheet from measured token costs (per seat vs. per call)
SAY	AI product questions: AI vs. rules (5 practice answers), fallbacks, human in the loop; one mock
REACH	Lighter: 8 to 10 messages, 2 applications
PORTFOLIO	Eval report page. Checkpoint 8 Nov
CONCEPT	Queues and async work: batch vs. real-time, Kafka or SQS, backpressure
TRACK 2	AI solutions one-pager: discovery questions to ask a customer before an AI use case

▼ Week 6: Agents, part 1: the loop (9 to 15 Nov, about 25 h)

BUILD	Agent loop with tools, memory across turns, guardrails (refund rule) and human handoff; second tool: call-history lookup over a synthetic table, so the agent flags repeat-caller churn risk and hands high-risk cases to a human; Udemy modules for concepts
MAKE	Market sizing for agent assist
SAY	Design drill: agentic assistant (single vs. multi-agent, tool permissions, failures); one mock
REACH	8 to 10 messages, 4 applications
PORTFOLIO	Decision record 2 (agent design); demo video v1
CONCEPT	Reliability: timeouts, retries with backoff, circuit breakers, fallbacks

TRACK 2	Debug lab 1: a broken API call (401, 429, timeout), fixed in 30 minutes, out loud

▼ Week 7: Agents, part 2: MCP and orchestration (16 to 22 Nov, about 25 h)

BUILD	Small MCP server exposing the refund and disclaimer checkers, knowledge lookup and call-history lookup; router and worker pattern; agent evals for task success and tool-call accuracy; optional (2 to 3 h): rebuild the week 6 agent with LangChain or LangGraph and note what was easier and harder than your hand-built loop
MAKE	Build-vs-buy story with an AI twist: would you build AXM on today's tools?
SAY	Full mock loop 1 (product sense, execution, technical, behavioral)
REACH	Keep the weekly rhythm
PORTFOLIO	MCP server folder with its own README. Checkpoint 22 Nov
CONCEPT	Scaling and cost: horizontal vs. vertical, load balancers, stateless services, autoscaling vs. manual
TRACK 2	Integration lab: a tiny mock CRM API (like Siebel) that your agent calls as a tool

▼ Week 8: Agents, part 3: production thinking (23 to 29 Nov, about 25 h)

BUILD	Log every call (tokens, latency, cost, outcome) to SQLite with a cost and quality chart; red-team set (prompt injection, jailbreaks, PII leaks); small PII redactor for card and phone numbers with tests; log the summarizer's cost per call
MAKE	PRD v1 final: problem, users, metrics, eval results, risks, rollout, monitoring, incident response, a cost model, and all four business problems with the cost of each error
SAY	Incident mock: the agent promised a refund, what do you do?
REACH	Keep the weekly rhythm
PORTFOLIO	PRD v1 and red-team report published
CONCEPT	Security and privacy: authentication vs. authorization, encryption, PII, multi-tenancy, audit logs
TRACK 2	Debug lab 2: a RAG answer that cites the wrong source; find out why

▼ Week 9: Data and experiments (30 Nov to 6 Dec, about 18 h)

BUILD	Synthetic call-records table in SQLite; SQL for funnels, handle time, resolution rate, cohorts, repeat-call rate, disclaimer pass rate; A/B test design for agent assist
MAKE	Experiment design document
SAY	Full mock loop 2; non-AI design drill: multi-channel inbox and routing system (AXM)
REACH	Second wave of applications
PORTFOLIO	SQL folder and experiment document
CONCEPT	Data pipelines: ETL, warehouse vs. lake, event streaming, A/B test basics
TRACK 2	TPM plan: roll the copilot out to 600 agents in phases, with risks and metrics

▼ Week 10: Deployment and system design (7 to 13 Dec, about 22 h)

BUILD	Wrap the copilot in a FastAPI service, package it in Docker, call it from a separate script that sends a call-ended event to a webhook endpoint
MAKE	Final architecture document: components, data flow, scaling, cost, latency, privacy and data residency, failure modes, decisions log
SAY	45-minute end-to-end AI design mock with a non-AI follow-up (10x traffic, what breaks first?); company-specific prep
REACH	Keep applications and follow-ups going
PORTFOLIO	Architecture document. Checkpoint 13 Dec: fallback decision
CONCEPT	Deployment and monitoring: CI/CD, environments, feature flags, canary releases, rollbacks, logs vs. metrics vs. traces
TRACK 2	Live debug: a broken webhook, 30 minutes, explained aloud

▼ Week 11: Kubernetes stretch and polish (14 to 20 Dec, about 18 h)

BUILD	Choose one (8 to 10 h): deploy the container to a small cloud service on AWS with a billing alert (first choice), or run it on local Kubernetes (pods, deployments, services, scaling, limits); skip if in live loops
MAKE	Portfolio polish: README, demo video, LinkedIn Featured, one write-up post; FDE pack (2 to 3 h): three Uniphore deployments as forward-deployed stories, a customer-style deployment guide, a 5-minute live demo script
SAY	Negotiation practice

REACH	Follow-ups before the year-end freeze
PORTFOLIO	Polished repo
TRACK 2	FDE pack, then the cloud deploy

▼ **Week 12: Close** (21 to 27 Dec, about 8 h)

BUILD	Maintenance only; fix what interviewers flagged
MAKE	Offer comparison; plan for the January pipeline
SAY	Final mocks for any live loops
REACH	Close open threads
TRACK 2	Mock FDE or solutions interview: a customer scenario plus a code walkthrough

Four business problems in the capstone

- **Compliance:** refund promise and required disclaimer (golden set in week 5, MCP tool in week 7)
- **Repeat-caller churn risk:** agent with call-history lookup and human handoff (weeks 6 and 7)
- **After-call summary:** effect on handle time and cost per call (weeks 8 and 9)
- **Privacy:** PII redaction in transcripts, tied to data residency (week 8)
- No extra hours: these reuse the planned build slots. Weeks 1 to 4 are unchanged.

Self-test: 25 items

Explain each to a non-engineer in 2 minutes and to an engineer in 5. Each Sunday mark green (clear, out loud), amber (partly) or red (stuck). Amber and red items go into next week's technical hours.

Core (1 to 10), all green by week 9

1. How an LLM produces an answer and why it sometimes gets it wrong
2. What RAG is and what breaks it
3. How to measure quality for an AI feature before launch
4. How an agent decides what to do and how to keep it safe
5. How real-time speech analytics works end to end
6. REST API vs. webhook, and when to use each
7. What a funnel or cohort query looks like in SQL

8. What an AI feature costs per call and how to reduce it
9. How data residency affects architecture
10. How to run an A/B test on an AI feature

System design (11 to 20), all green by week 10

11. What happens when an API call fails: retries, timeouts, idempotency
12. p50, p95, p99 latency, and why p99 matters more than the average
13. Batch vs. real-time (post-call analytics vs. live agent assist)
14. What a message queue does and what problem it solves
15. Horizontal vs. vertical scaling; when autoscaling saves or wastes money
16. What a cache is and what can go wrong with one
17. Authentication vs. authorization; protecting PII in a call transcript
18. Logs, metrics and traces; what to watch after launching an AI feature
19. Feature flags and canary releases for safe rollout and rollback
20. SQL vs. NoSQL vs. vector database: which job each fits

AI and speech (21 to 25), all green by week 12

21. Prompting vs. RAG vs. fine-tuning, with a cost example
22. Tokens and the context window; why long chats cost more
23. Small vs. large model, and routing between them to save cost
24. Word error rate and speaker separation; why mono audio hurt U-Analyze
25. Streaming vs. batch speech recognition and the effect on latency

Outreach targets and playbook

8 to 10
warm outreach a week

3 to 4
tailored applications a week (from week 2)

2 to 3
referral conversations a week (from week 3)

3+ / 8+
screens by week 6 / week 10

2+
full loops by week 10

Rules

1. Referral first: ask for a referral the same day you apply
2. Messages under 90 words: who you are, one proof point (the AXM cost story), one clear ask
3. Attach a one-page teardown with 2 or 3 ideas for their product

4. Mirror the job description in the top third of the CV, honestly
5. Show work in public: the project and two short posts
6. State availability: can start immediately
7. Be plain about the layoff: one factual sentence, then the work
8. Follow up on day 3 and day 8, short and polite
9. Apply within 48 hours of a posting, Tuesday to Thursday mornings
10. Have a 90-second 'why PM now' story

Risks to manage

- Downlevelling: most offers may be Senior PM. Decide now whether scope and pay work for you.
- Over-building: time-box the project. Small and finished beats large and unfinished.
- Technical overreach: never claim what you cannot defend. Talk about what you built, measured and what failed.
- Burnout: keep the day off and the fixed finish time.
- Slow year-end hiring: outreach and interviews are front-loaded for this reason.

Copilot modules

- Wk 1 summarizer and refund checker
- Wk 2 keyword retrieval
- Wk 3 tool-use agent and eval script
- Wk 4 RAG with embeddings
- Wk 5 eval harness
- Wk 6 agent loop with guardrails
- Wk 7 MCP server
- Wk 8 observability, PII redaction and red-team tests
- Wk 9 SQL analytics
- Wk 10 API in Docker with a webhook endpoint
- Wk 11 cloud deploy or Kubernetes (choose one)